The Price of Flexibility

What PMEs value, what employers weigh, and where they meet

Seonghoon Kim

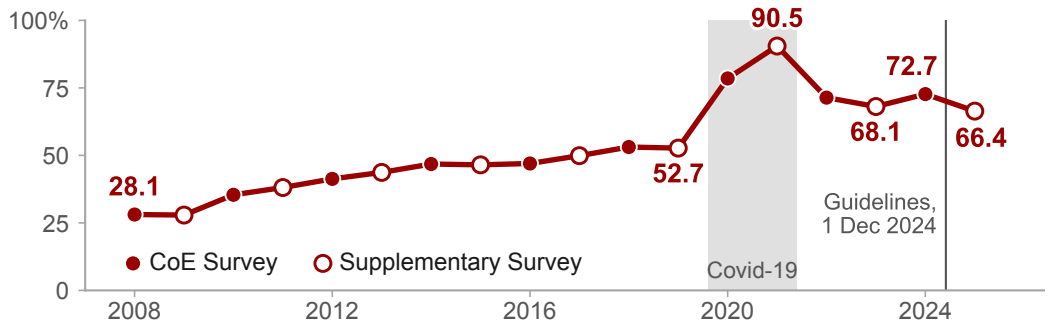
Singapore Management University

Joint work with the Singapore National Employers Federation (SNEF)

Preliminary findings for tripartite discussion | January 2027

Flexible work is mainstream; the policy problem is fit

Establishments (25+ staff, incl. public sector) offering a scheduled FWA, %



Aggregate provision does not tell us whether the arrangements offered are the ones workers value and firms can sustain.

Source: MRSD, MOM (Jun 2026). MOM gives no reason for the 2025 fall; 2024 incl. newer types: 77.5%.

▸ Labour supply ▸ Guidelines

The open problem is fit, not whether a process exists

Arrangement fit

Aggregate provision masks which arrangements are available, and whether they fit the worker and the role.

Two sides, measured together

Worker value and employers' hiring reservations are rarely measured together.

Barriers

Career, information and redesign barriers can block mutually beneficial use.

Which arrangements create common ground, for which roles, and what blocks adoption?

▸ Guidelines ▸ Partners

Two-sided evidence remains limited

	What existing work measures	**What it finds** (not like-for-like)	**What this study adds**
Worker value of WFH	Pay workers would give up for a WFH option	About 4–8% of pay; Singapore 4.8%, in an online, mostly tertiary-educated sample	Seven arrangements, one design
Employer side and productivity	Employers' expected costs; quits in a firm trial	Poland (2023 working paper, hybrid and remote pooled): workers give up 2.9%, employers expect a 21% wage cut. Hybrid trial: quits fell by a third	Employers' hiring choices, mirrored with PMEs'
Singapore	Which firms offer FWAs; stated intentions	Provision is widespread; FWAs raise stated fertility intentions	Both sides' choices, after the Guidelines took effect

References: Mas & Pallais 2017; Maestas et al. 2023; Aksoy et al. 2022; Lewandowski et al. 2023; Bloom et al. 2024; MRSD; Wang & Dong 2024.

▸ Benchmarks ▸ Trials

Three zones, three policy moves

Zone	PMEs	Employers, in hiring	Policy move
A **Common ground**	Value it	No hiring penalty detected	→ **Make it easier to try**
B **Depends on the role**	Value it	Reservations vary with the role's tasks	→ **Redesign and test by role**
C **Far apart**	Value it highly	Strong hiring reservation	→ **Pilot before scaling**

Career signal · **redesign** · **information** can block use in any zone

▸ Methods ▸ Trials

Two surveys, unweighted online panels

1,020 PMEs

Singapore citizens and PRs in or seeking PME roles

Online panels, unweighted
Fielded 4–21 Aug 2026

397 employer respondents

People involved in PME hiring or manpower decisions

Online panel, unweighted
Fielded 12 Aug–2 Sep 2026

Employer respondents' firms, by staff size



Shares describe surveyed PMEs and firms, not national rates.

Source: this study's PME survey (Aug 2026) and employer survey (Aug–Oct 2026).

▸ Sample ▸ Panels

Mirrored choices on a common FWA menu

PMEs choose a job		Common menu	Employers choose a hire	
Job Offer A	**Job Offer B**		**Candidate A**	**Candidate B**
+10% vs own pay	**–10%** vs own pay	**Monthly pay**	**+10%** vs last PME hire	**–10%** vs last PME hire
Fully onsite	1–2 days WFH	**Work location**	Fully onsite	1–2 days WFH
Fixed hours	Compressed 4-day week	**Work schedule**	Fixed hours	Compressed 4-day week
Same in both: as in own job		**Everything else**	Same in both: as in own firm	

Six forced choices each | Pay gaps $\approx$ 17–33% | Employer task = hiring, not a request

1,020 surveyed PMEs · 397 people involved in PME hiring or manpower decisions
Online, unweighted panels · 20% of employer respondents' firms have 50 or fewer staff

▸ Choice cards ▸ Sample

How we turn choices into values

Illustrative choice task

Scenario 1 of 6

Attribute	Job Offer A	Job Offer B
Monthly gross salary for this job	Your pay +10%	Your pay −10%
Work location	Fully onsite (0 days WFH)	1–2 days WFH/week
Work schedule	Fixed hours (9am–6pm)	Compressed 4-day week

Workload, Job security, Workplace culture, Commute time: same for A and B (your current job)

How values are calculated

1 Choose A or B, six times

↓

2 Estimate how pay and each FWA shift choices

↓

3 Translate the average effect into:

% of pay (indicative): the pay gap that makes A and B equally attractive

Equal-pay share: how often the FWA option wins if pay is equal; 50% = no preference

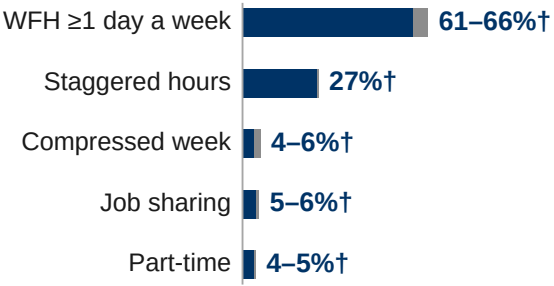
No equal-pay pair was shown; observed pay gaps were about 17–33%, so rankings are firmer than prices.

Source: PME questionnaire, Section D. Employers saw the same layout with Candidates A and B.

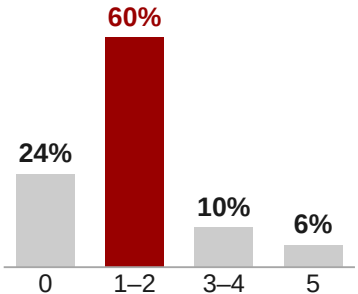
▸ Equations ▸ Equal pay ▸ Validity

Hybrid is common; compressed weeks are rare

Employed PMEs (n = 1,004)
% using each arrangement



Employers (n = 397)
Typical PME WFH days a week



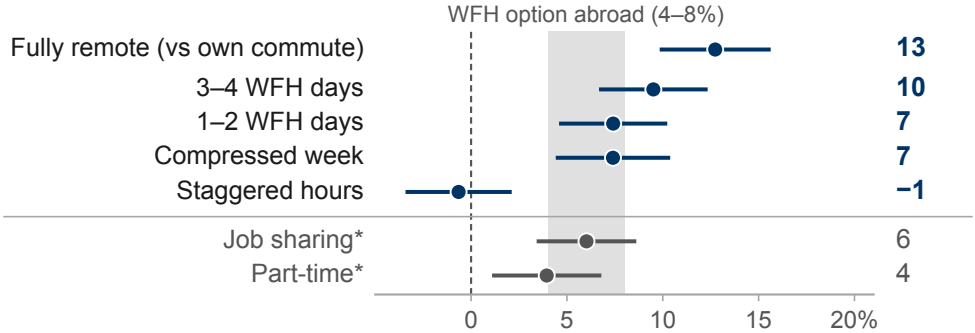
Among surveyed firms, 60% call 1–2 WFH days typical for PMEs; only 4–6%† of surveyed PMEs use a compressed week.

Note: †Range across all respondents and excluding one online panel. **Source:** this study's PME and employer surveys (Aug–Oct 2026).

Landscape Pathways

PMEs strongly prefer hybrid work

Pay PMEs would give up for each arrangement, % of monthly pay

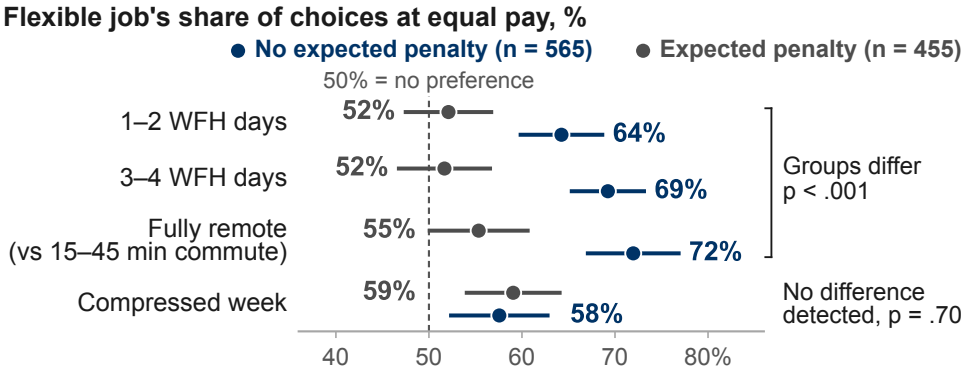


The model implies about 7–10% of pay for hybrid work:
indicative, not a proposed pay cut; observed pay gaps were about 17–33%.

Note: * Hours change too: not a price of flexibility. Lines: 95% CIs. **Source:** PME survey (n = 1,020), Aug 2026 (online panels).

▸ All estimates ▸ By commute

Career concerns track lower demand for WFH



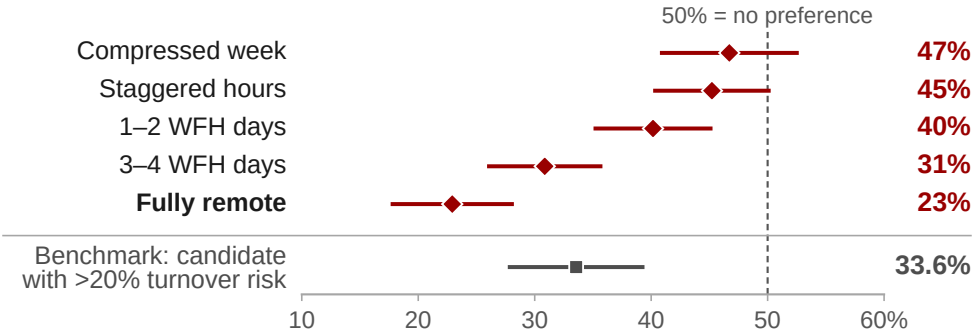
Consistent with a visibility concern, but asked after the choices and weaker outside one panel.

Note: Penalty: agrees flexible hours would hurt their career. Associations; lines: 95% CIs. **Source:** PME survey (n = 1,020), Aug 2026.

▸ All splits ▸ Career risk

Employers rank fully remote last in hiring

Hiring choices for the flexible candidate at equal pay, %



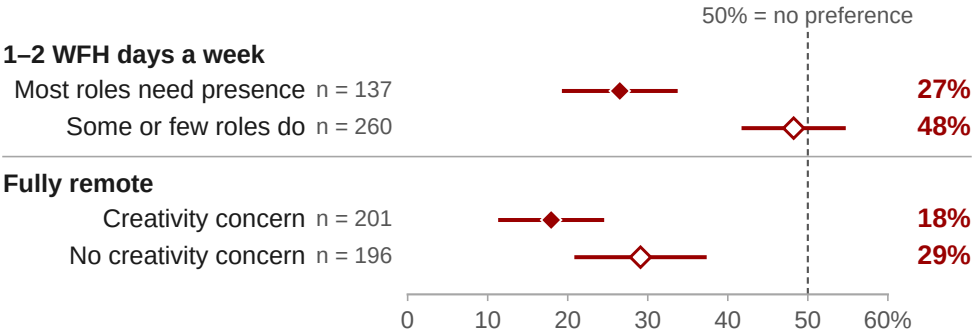
Ranking, not a salary price: shares of hiring choices at equal pay; 50% = no preference. Reservations may reflect operating needs, uncertainty or a candidate signal.

Note: Lines: 95% CIs. Model-based shares: no pair in the survey had equal pay. **Source:** employer survey (n = 397), Aug–Oct 2026.

Yardstick Salary lever

Employer reservations vary with role needs and concerns

Hiring choices for the flexible candidate at equal pay, %



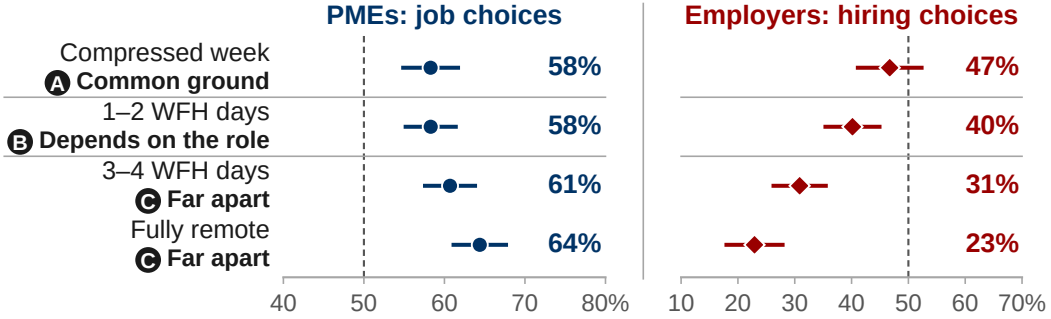
Preliminary associations under a common pay-slope model;
both items asked after the choices; presence q = .002, creativity q = .43 across 20 splits.

Note: Filled: firms with the need or concern; hollow: other firms. Lines: 95% CIs. **Source:** employer survey (n = 397), Aug–Oct 2026.

▸ Tests ▸ Concerns ▸ Employer view

Each side, against its own 50%

Compare each side with its own 50%; do not compare distances across sides

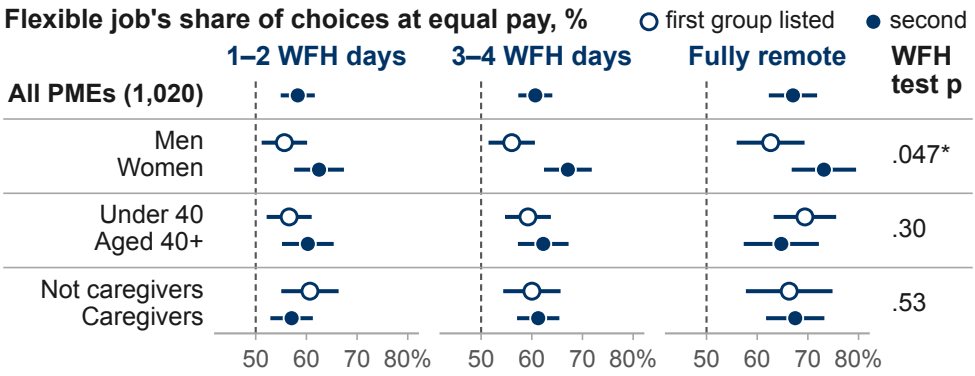


Compressed week: most promising common-ground test; evidence moderate; operating costs unmeasured.

Note: % of choices at equal pay; 95% CIs. Zones A–C: descriptive labels. PMEs' remote vs own commute. **Source:** choice experiments with 1,020 surveyed PMEs and 397 employer respondents (Aug–Oct 2026).

▸ Equal pay ▸ Wording

No subgroup difference detected after correction



Non-rejection is not equivalence; groups may still differ.

Note: Lines: 95% CIs. Fully remote: vs a >45 min commute. * Nominal: none of 198 subgroup contrasts survives multiple-testing correction. **Source:** PME choice experiment (1,020 surveyed PMEs).

▸ All groups ▸ All splits

The compressed week: valued, rarely offered

PMEs value it

50% = no preference

58%

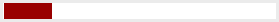


of PMEs' job choices at equal pay

Few firms offer it

1 in 6

18%

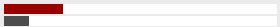


of surveyed firms offer it to PMEs

Goes with a written FWA policy

21.4%

vs 9.1%

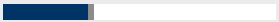


of firms with / without a written policy offer it

Take-up where available

1 in 3

31–33%†



of PMEs with access use it

This supports a voluntary, evaluated pilot, not a claim that adoption is costless.

Note: †Range across all respondents and excluding one online panel. Surveyed samples, unweighted. Design: where only one option had it, the compressed week was the cheaper one in 83% of PME and 91% of employer pairs.

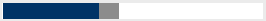
▸ Offering ▸ Pilot checklist

We see outcomes for requesters, not why others do not ask

Not conditional on asking

Career concern

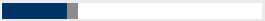
37–45%†



of PMEs agree shorter or more flexible hours would hurt their career

Know the Guidelines

25–29%†

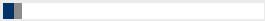


of junior PMEs are familiar with the Guidelines (all levels: 44–55%†)

Reported requesters

Outright refusal

4–7%†



of PMEs who report a formal request: a selected lower bound

Career concern covers all surveyed PMEs; refusals cover only reported requesters. We cannot say why others did not ask.

Note: †Range across all respondents and excluding one online panel. Grey: the gap between the two. **Source:** PME survey (Aug 2026).

▸ Who expects ▸ Approvals

Rankings are more credible than levels

Check	Concern	Result
Excl. one panel	Data quality	PMEs: at most 2 points (3–4 days: 11.5 vs 9.5)
Pay outliers; 1% trim	Implausible pay	Arrangements: about 1 point or less, both sides
Same-side answers	Inattention	PMEs: about 1 point or less; employers: same significance
Position term	Left-option bias	Arrangements: at most 2 points, both sides
Version clusters	Only 60 choice situations	Holds, except employer staggered hours ($p = .15$)
Rank pay model	How pay enters	Fits about as well on both sides; same ranking

Pay gaps were 17–33% by design, so levels in % of pay are model-based;
60 choice situations per side; employer hiring-task validity untested.

Source: choice experiments with 1,020 surveyed PMEs and 397 employer respondents (Aug–Oct 2026).

▸ Validity ▸ Checks

What the evidence says about each zone

Zone	PMEs	Employers	Barriers	Policy move
A **Common ground** Compressed week	Value it	No detectable hiring penalty	Rarely offered; operating costs unmeasured	**Voluntary, evaluated pilot (A)**
B **Depends on the role** 1–2 WFH days	Value it; less with career concern	Reservations where most roles need presence†	Presence needs; career concern	**Review tasks by role; flexi-load (B)**
C **Far apart** 3–4 WFH days; fully remote	Value them; remote most	Remote ranked last; strong reservations	Creativity concern†; career concern	**3–4-day WFH pilot; test before scaling (C)**

Every zone: no request counts, and why PMEs do not ask is not in published data **(D)**

Note: † Preliminary association under a common pay-slope model. **Source:** PME and employer surveys (Aug–Oct 2026).

▸ Trials abroad ▸ Offering

Options for the partners' decision

Decision today: one measurement step (we propose D) and one bounded, voluntary pilot (we propose A), each with a lead.

Option	Owner and first step	Evidence strength
A Pilot: put compressed weeks on the written menu and test them	SNEF and volunteer firms; NTUC: safeguards; TAFEP: guidance	Moderate; operating costs unmeasured
B Support: review which tasks need presence; flexi-load where fewer hours, not location, address the need	Firms, with Job Redesign+; MOM's PTRG review	Moderate; preliminary associations
C Pilot: 3–4-day WFH pilot in roles without presence needs	Volunteer firms; independent evaluation	Exploratory
D Measure: why-not-request and partial-approval survey items	MRSD checks the items against its survey, with NTUC and SNEF	Gap documented

None requires a change to the Guidelines.

▸ Option A ▸ Survey items ▸ Pilot checklist

What we cannot yet say

Limit	What it means
Stated choices	Hypothetical offers; respondents knew SNEF would use the results; rankings firmer than levels
Online panels	Unweighted surveyed PMEs and firms, not national rates; no rank-and-file staff
Employer task	Hiring, not a staff request; may also reflect candidate signals; operating costs unmeasured
Few design cells	60 choice situations per side; pay gaps 17–33% by design; intervals likely too narrow
Employer splits	Free-slope check pending: preliminary associations under a common pay-slope model
Request item	Partly misread; why PMEs do not ask is unmeasured

▸ All limits ▸ Next steps

The decision we ask of the partners

Decision sought today: one measurement step and one bounded, voluntary practice pilot, with a lead for each.

Take-away messages

1. PMEs strongly prefer hybrid work: the model implies **about 7–10% of pay** (indicative, not a pay cut)
2. Compressed week: **most promising common-ground test**; evidence moderate; operating costs unmeasured
3. Employers rank **fully remote last** in hiring: a ranking, not a salary price

We propose D (why-not and partial-approval items) and A (a compressed-week pilot).

▸ Follow-up ▸ Survey items

Thank you

Questions and discussion

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Joint work with the Singapore National Employers Federation (SNEF)

▸ Backup index

Backup index: likely questions

Policy and practice

- Did the Guidelines change outcomes?
- Should FWA requests be legislated?
- Is this a burden for smaller firms?
- How would a compressed-week pilot run?
- Why do some PMEs not ask?
- What next, and with whose consent?

The evidence

- Is the career risk real?
- Are reservations about roles or concerns?
- Is the compressed-week result a design artefact?
- Can employer reservations be priced?

The study

- Do stated choices predict behaviour?

▸ Full backup index ◂ Conclusion ◂ Thank you

Full backup index

Motivation and question
Labour supply · Talent
Partners' evidence · Guidelines
Partner positions · Abroad

Framework
Evidence elsewhere · Zone rules
Validity of stated choices

Data and design
Sample · Industries · Panels
Governance · Choice cards
Pay gaps · Why not pay data

Method
Equations · Equal-pay shares

Practice today
Landscape · Pathways

PMEs
All estimates · Commute
Benchmarks · All splits
By group · Access · Checks

Employers
Yardstick · Salary lever
Roles and concerns · Splits chart
Concerns · Own view; SMEs
No industry split

Where the sides meet
Raw choices · Compressed week
Pilot checklist · Flexi-load

Barriers
Who expects it · Career risk
On the Guidelines · Awareness
Approvals · Outcomes · Request rate

Limits and next steps
Limits · Next steps · Follow-up

Options
Option A B C D · D: items

Technical appendix
20 employer tests · Wording
Employer % of salary · Gap

PME groups
Gender · Age · Care
Role · Education

PME checks
Same-side · Trim

▸ Likely questions ◂ Thank you

Keeping people in work matters more

67.9%
resident participation, 2025 (fourth straight fall)

3.2 → 2.7
residents 20–64 per resident 65+, 2026 to 2030 (projected)

133,500 → 72,500
outside the labour force mainly to give care, 2019 to 2025

80.5%
female participation, ages 25–64 (2025)

< half
who needed part-time work got it (2024; COS 2026)

5.9% vs 13.7%
share of all women 25–64 in part-time work: Singapore (2025) vs OECD (2024)

Sources: MRSD Labour Force in Singapore 2025; Population in Brief 2026; MOM COS 2026; Labour Market Report 2Q 2026 (1.48 vacancies per unemployed person, Jun 2026). We survey PMEs in or seeking work, not carers outside the labour force. Checked 6 Oct 2026.

◂ Motivation

Backup index

Backup B3

What FWAs offer firms seeking talent

What we observe

- 52% of surveyed firms had difficulty filling PME roles last year
- 66% say FWAs help attract and retain talent; 26% plan to expand them
- PMEs value hybrid at $\approx$ 7–10% of pay, a compressed week $\approx$ 7% (indicative)
- Pay comes first: at 17–33% gaps, 3 in 4 chose the better-paid offer

Elsewhere

- Singapore: 65.9% of firms offering scheduled FWAs report better retention (employer-reported, mid-2024)
- A six-month hybrid trial abroad cut quits by one-third

What we cannot say

- Whether firms offering FWAs hire faster or keep staff longer

FWAs add to the reward package; not a basis for setting pay.

◂ Motivation ◂ Employers

Backup index

Backup B4

Partners' evidence and ours

Source	They found	We find
MOM, Working Conditions 2024	≈ 94% of requests approved; 18.5% ask formally	4–7%† of PMEs' formal requests declined outright (a lower bound)
MOM, CoE 2024	Firms with scheduled FWAs report gains: engagement 69.5%, retention 65.9%, productivity 59.9%	66% of employers: FWAs help attract and retain talent
PAP Women's Wing–NTUC (2025)[a]	36% name stigma the main concern; 58% aware; 89% of formal applicants approved, fully or with changes	37–45%† expect a career penalty; 77–83%† aware (44–55%† familiar); 93–96%† of formal requests approved, fully or partly
SUSS×SNEF (2024)	81% felt prepared; 22% thought they must approve every request	58% of employers familiar; 36% more have heard of them

[a]Online, N = 1,508; sampling not published. MOM (PQ, 2026): ≈ 6% of FWA users report a 2025 career setback (experience, not expectation). †Range across two samples: all respondents, and excluding one online panel with less reliable survey answers. Populations and questions differ: read as direction.

◂ Motivation ◂ Barriers

Backup index

Backup B5

The Guidelines: process, not outcome

1. Request
In writing by default

→ **2. Proper consideration**
On business needs

→ **3. Written decision**
Within 2 months; reasons if declined

In effect from 1 Dec 2024 for employees past probation. Cost, productivity and feasibility can be reasonable grounds to decline; custom or disbelief in FWAs cannot. TAFEP takes an educational approach, guiding employers to comply (MOM, 2026).

MOM indicators, 2024 data: not one funnel; definitions differ

84.5%
who needed a scheduled FWA got one they needed

≈ 94%
of requests approved; base not defined

18.5%
of those in need asked formally; 26.3% informally

Full-time residents aged 25–64, almost entirely before the Guidelines; MOM reads the gap as "frictions", not employer resistance. Firms need not report requests to MOM. Establishments (25+ staff) offering a scheduled FWA: 72.7% (Jun 2024), 66.4% (Jun 2025; another MOM survey; not attributed to the Guidelines).

Sources: Tripartite Guidelines (2024); MRSD (May and Jun 2026); MOM PQ replies (2025–26); COS 2026. Checked 6 Oct 2026.

◂ Question ◂ Motivation

Backup index

Backup B6

What each partner has said

- **MOM:** reads the need-request gap as “frictions … rather than employer resistance”; at COS 2026 called a proposal to make the Guidelines law, and FWAs a presumptive right for parents of young children, “too blunt”, as business needs differ by industry and role.
- **SNEF:** endorses the Guidelines on three principles: outcomes stay the employer’s prerogative; FWAs must not harm productivity or service quality; not every role suits every FWA. SUSS×SNEF (367 firms, 2024): 81% felt prepared.
- **NTUC:** FWA access is often the main consideration for caregivers, women and senior workers in staying in or returning to work. PAP Women’s Wing–NTUC survey (online, N = 1,508; sampling not published): 36% named stigma their primary concern in requesting an FWA (most cited).

Sources: MRSD (2026); MOM COS 2026 (3 Mar 2026); SNEF statement (23 Apr 2024); SUSS–SNEF (2025); MOM release (16 Apr 2024); PAP Women’s Wing, NTUC (Mar 2026).

◂ Question

Backup index

Backup B7

FWA request rules elsewhere

- **Singapore:** tripartite guidelines on the process, not the outcome; TAFEP takes an educational approach.
- **Great Britain:** statutory right to request from day one (since Apr 2024); decision within 2 months; refusal only on eight listed business reasons; a tribunal if a request is not handled reasonably, not merely if refused. Employment Rights Act 2025 changes due in 2027.
- **Australia:** eligible employees (e.g. parents, carers, 55+); written reply within 21 days; refusal only on reasonable business grounds; the Fair Work Commission can arbitrate and, as a last resort, order it granted. **New Zealand:** any employee; reply within 1 month; eight listed grounds; disputes cover process only. In both, most requests are informal.
- **Why guidelines here:** the Workgroup judged legislation risks an acrimonious workplace culture; at COS 2026, MOM called legislating the Guidelines, with a presumptive FWA right for parents of young children, too blunt.

Sources: MOM COS 2026, FAQ (Jun 2026); Workgroup report (2024); gov.uk/flexible-working; Fair Work Act 2009 ss65–65C; Employment Relations Act 2000 (NZ) Part 6AA. Checked 6 Oct 2026.

◂ Options ◂ Question

Backup index

Backup B8

Evidence elsewhere: concerns and trials

- **Poland, two-sided experiment:** workers give up 2.9% of pay for remote work; employers expect a 21% wage cut, mostly for lost productivity (Lewandowski et al., IZA DP 16041, 2023; hybrid and fully remote pooled). ILR Review (2026) version: gaps $\approx$5% (hybrid), 25% (fully remote).
- **Randomised hybrid trial** (two days a week; 1,612 graduates, one Chinese firm): quits fell by one-third over six months; over two years, reviews were unaffected and promotions showed no statistically significant difference; managers' productivity view: -2.6% to $+1.0\%$ (Bloom, Han & Liang, Nature 2024).
- **Singapore firms offering scheduled FWAs:** 69.5% report better engagement, 65.9% retention, 59.9% productivity (employer-reported, mid-2024; MRSD).
- **Fully remote:** evidence is mixed and job-dependent; several studies find lower productivity, partly reflecting who selects into remote jobs (Barrero, Bloom & Davis 2023; Emanuel & Harrington 2024).

Other settings; read as context. Trip.com trial: co-author James Liang co-founded and chairs Trip.com.

◂ Framework ◂ Discussion

Backup index

Backup B9

How the zones are set

Zone	Rule (equal-pay share vs 50%)	Arrangements
A Common ground	PMEs >50%; employers 47%, not distinguishable from 50%; only fully tech-ready firms (40%) fall below 50% (p = .04, uncorrected)	Compressed week
B Depends on the role	PMEs >50%; employers below 50%, but 48% in firms where only some or few roles need presence	1–2 days WFH
C Far apart	PMEs >50%; employers below 50% overall (31%, 23%) and where only some or few roles need presence (35%, 26%); with neither need nor concern, 3–4 days is not detectably below 50% (44%), fully remote is (38%)	3–4 days WFH; fully remote
Little at stake	PMEs ≈ 50%	Staggered hours
Pay for hours	Fewer hours at the same pay; employer values ≈ pro-rata	Part-time; reduced load

Descriptive labels, not one ruler across sides; role splits preliminary (one pay slope). Employer tests: compressed vs 1–2 days p = .09; 1–2 vs 3–4 days $p < .001$; 3–4 days vs remote p = .003; compressed vs 1–2 days in presence-heavy firms $p < .001$.

◂ Two sides ◂ Framework

Backup index

Backup B10

Do stated choices predict real choices?

Maestas et al. (AER 2023)	US workers, up to 3 years on: 977 of 1,738 (56%) matched; kept vs lost an amenity: +4.1 pp (1% level); gained: +1.7 pp (n.s.)
Wiswall & Zafar (QJE 2018)	NYU students, about 4 years on (59 working): 6 of 6 links to actual jobs with the expected sign, 3 significant at 5%; joint test of no link p = .012
Mas & Pallais (AER 2017)	Call-centre applicants: WFH 8.4% of pay, survey (reweighted to field commute times) vs 7.8%, field; scheduling 2.5% vs 2.8%
Hainmueller et al. (PNAS 2015)	Swiss voters: paired conjoint (best of 5 designs) within 2 pp of referendum effects on average (21 effects); levels missed (21% vs 37% rejection)
Health DCE meta-analyses	Opting in predicted well; opting out weakly (pooled specificity 34–52%)

- **Rankings hold best:** direction right and, in one direct test, relative size; our ranking is the firmest result.
- **Levels less so:** rates predicted less well, money values mixed; our % of pay values are indicative.
- **Our design:** one cross-section; pay gaps of 17–33% only; no link yet to behaviour.

No cited study validates employer hiring choices of this form; our follow-up addresses only part of that gap.

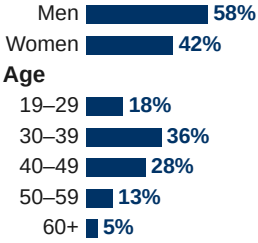
Maestas: split by amenity status; mean of 12 amenities.

◂ Estimation ◂ Robustness

Who answered

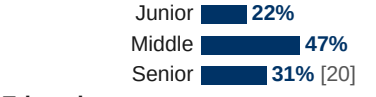
PMEs (n = 1,020)

Gender

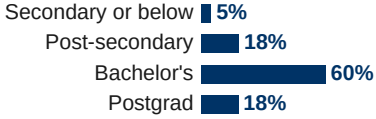


Age

Role

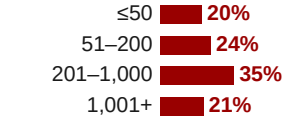


Education

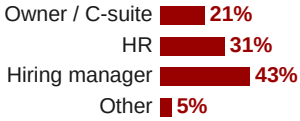


Employers (n = 397)

Firm size (staff)



Role



3 PMEs (0.3%) gave no gender. [ ] = excl. one panel.

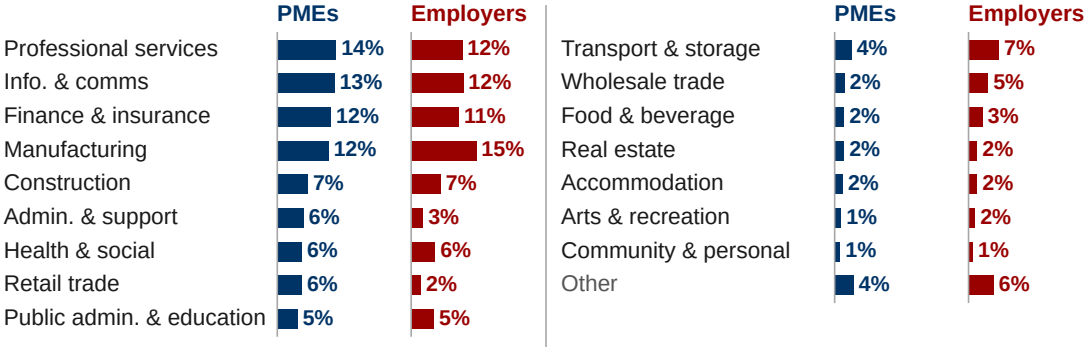
PMEs: citizens and PRs in or seeking PME roles, two online panels (73 with no panel recorded). Employers: people involved in PME hiring or manpower decisions; 20% of their firms have 50 or fewer staff. Unweighted.

◂ Design ◂ Data

Backup index

Backup B12

Respondents span the main industries



% of each sample; sorted by PME share.

Employed PMEs (n = 1,004), employers (n = 397). Unweighted.

Data

Weaker panel: choice results hold

PMEs	Full	Excl. panel	Message changes?
1–2 days WFH, % of pay	≈7	≈7	No
3–4 days WFH, % of pay	≈10	≈11	No
Fully remote[1], % of pay	≈15	≈15	No
Compressed week, % of pay	≈7	≈6	No
Pick a 3–4 day WFH job, equal pay, %	61	66	No: stronger without (52 within; p = .013)
Penalty belief vs not, 1–2 WFH days, %	52 vs 64	53 vs 65	Holds; scale-free test weaker (p = .048)
Familiar with the Guidelines, %	55	44	Lower; both shown
Declined, % of requests	4.4	7.2	No: few (a lower bound)
Report a formal request, %	65.7	51.7	Item misread; not headlined
Agree FWAs hurt career, %	45	37	No: more than a third
Parents of a child 0–6, adjusted gap, pp	+12	+8	Weaker: significant at 10% only

Excl. panel: without the Lucid panel (n = 312 of 1,020). [1]vs onsite with a long commute. Grey = indicative.

◂ Data ◂ Robustness

Backup index

Backup B14

Study governance

Item	Status
Ethics (SMU IRB)	Category 1, exempt from further review: IRB-26-069-E012(326), 19 Mar 2026
Partnership	Joint work with SNEF
Funding	**[PI to confirm]**
Survey and design roles	**[PI to confirm]**
Custody of identifiable data	**[PI to confirm]**
Custody of de-identified data	**[PI to confirm]**
Who ran the analysis	**[PI to confirm]**
Right to publish	**[PI to confirm]**
Partner delay or veto rights	**[PI to confirm]**

Both surveys told respondents that SNEF would use the results to inform workplace flexibility policy. Items marked [PI to confirm] need written agreement before external use.

◂ Data ◂ Conclusion

Backup index

Nearly the same cards on both sides

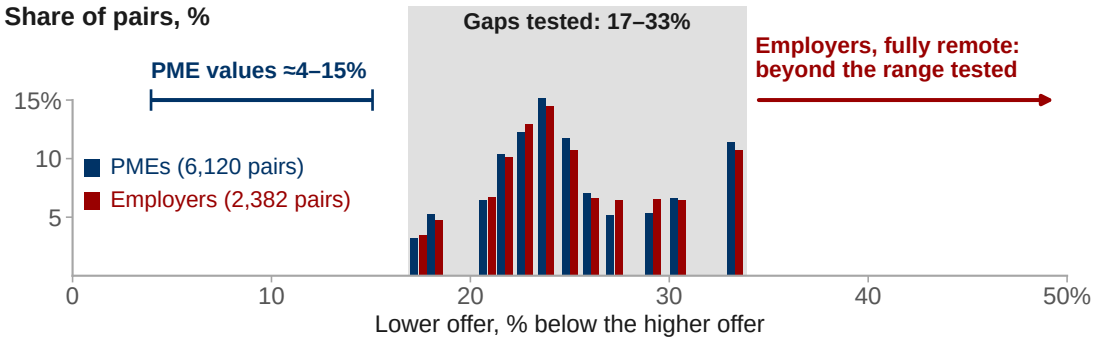
Attribute	PMEs (job offers)	Employers (candidates)
Salary	Own salary $\times$ multiplier	Latest PME-hire salary $\times$ multiplier
Location	Onsite; 1–2 WFH days a week; 3–4 days; fully remote	Same
Schedule	Fixed 9am–6pm; staggered; compressed 4-day week (same hours, longer days)	Same
Workload	Full-time (35–44 h); *job sharing (4 days)*; part-time ($<$35 h)	Full-time; *reduced load (4 days)*; part-time
Risk	Job loss (low / moderate / high)	Turnover (low $<$10% / moderate / high $>$20%)
Other	Culture; commute	Culture
Design	6 forced choices between 2 options; each pair differs in salary and two attributes, the rest held at the respondent's own practice. Multipliers 0.80–0.95 vs 1.05–1.20, closest pairs never drawn: every gap is 17–33%. 10 versions.	

Employers were told both candidates are equally qualified.

◂ Design

Backup index

Every pair differed in pay by 17–33%



Pay gap within each choice pair. PME values (≈4–15% of pay) lie below this band and the employer estimates for 3–4 WFH days, fully remote and part-time above it: both extrapolate beyond the gaps shown. Equal-pay choices skip the pay slope but assume effects add up.

◂ Design ◂ Estimation

Backup index

Backup B17

Pay data cannot price flexibility

Current arrangement (vs onsite / full-time)	Observed pay difference, %	Value in the experiment, % of pay
1–2 days WFH	+37	≈7
3–4 days WFH	+36	≈10
Fully remote[1]	+42	≈15
Part-time	−53	≈4

Observed: log current pay on current arrangement, with job and personal controls (N = 991 employed PMEs). FWAs sit in better-paid jobs and part-time hours are fewer, so these differences are not prices.
[1] Experiment: vs onsite with a long commute. Grey = indicative.

Log salary on current arrangement, controlling for age, gender, education, residency; employed PMEs. It shows who has flexibility (FWAs sit in better-paid jobs), not its worth; the experiment isolates the trade-off.

◂ Design

Backup index

Backup B18

Equations and inference

$$U_{ijt} = \beta_w \ln w_{ijt} + \sum_k \beta_k x_{kijt} + \varepsilon_{ijt}$$

Conditional logit per side; SEs clustered by respondent.

Per cent of pay: $100\,[1 - \exp(-\beta_k/\beta_w)]$

Pay a PME would give up, or the discount an employer would need. Indicative: gaps shown were 17–33%, and a which-paid-more indicator fits about as well.

Equal-pay share: $\Lambda(\beta_k) = e^{\beta_k}/(1 + e^{\beta_k})$

How often k wins at equal pay; 50% = no preference, within a side. No pay slope: for the seven arrangements, moves $\leq$1 point (employers), $\leq$3 (PMEs) across pay models; assumes effects add up.

- **Tests:** 60 choice situations per side, so intervals may be too narrow. Benjamini–Hochberg by family: 198 PME contrasts, 7 PME mechanisms, 20 employer splits.
- **Pay slopes:** one slope for all groups. PMEs: group slopes added after the pre-specified tests. Employers' presence and creativity splits: check pending, so preliminary associations.
- **Checks:** without the weaker panel, outliers or same-side respondents, or with a position term, PME values move $\leq$2 points. To fix: position term; task-1 coding ($\approx$0.5 point, remote).

i respondent, j option, t task; w pay shown; x_k arrangement level k. McFadden (1974).

◂ Estimation ◂ Framework

Pay model barely moves equal-pay shares

	PMEs: flexible job		Employers: flexible hire	
Arrangement	**Main (95% CI)**	**Rank**	**Main (95% CI)**	**Rank**
1–2 days WFH	58 (55–62)	58	40 (35–45)	40
3–4 days WFH	61 (57–64)	58	31 (26–36)	30
Fully remote[1]	64 (60–68)	61	23 (18–28)	23
Staggered hours	49 (46–52)	47	45 (40–50)	45
Compressed week	58 (55–62)	56	47 (41–53)	46
Reduced load[2]	57 (54–60)	54	38 (34–42)	38
Part-time	54 (51–58)	53	31 (27–35)	32
High turnover (benchmark)	–	–	34 (28–39)	33
Collaborative culture	61 (55–66)	56	–	–

% of equal-pay choices won against an otherwise identical base (50 = no preference). Main: log pay; rank: pay enters only as which option paid more. [1]PMEs: vs a moderate commute (67 vs long, 58 vs short). [2]PMEs saw "job sharing".

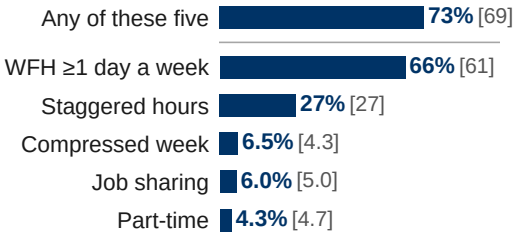
Own scale per side: compare shares with 50%, not across sides.

◂ Two sides ◂ Estimation

Flexible work today: PMEs and firms

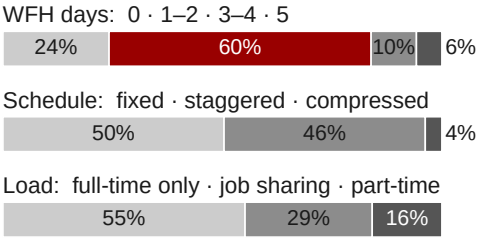
PMEs: current use

% of employed PMEs [excl. one panel]



Employers: typical PME arrangement

% of employers



Take-up: WFH 87% [85] · staggered 69% [75] · compressed 31% [33] · job sharing 27% [34] · part-time 26% [35]
Take-up = % using it among those with access (available or used).

PMEs: employed (n = 1,004); brackets exclude one lower-quality panel. Employers: n = 397. Unweighted online panels: shares describe surveyed PMEs and firms, not national rates.

◂ Practice ◂ Puzzle

Backup index

Most FWAs come via policy or request

PMEs: how FWA was set up (N = 869 [574])	%†	Employers (N = 397)	%
Company-wide policy (automatic)	43 [39]	Written policy: all firms	70
Individual request	30 [26]	... 200 or fewer staff	63
Informal, with manager	18 [23]	... 201–1,000 staff	73
Negotiated in contract	5 [6]	... 1,001 or more staff	78
Don't know	5 [7]	... size test (p)	.027
		Got formal requests: with policy[1]	68
		... without policy	19

† Full sample [excl. one lower-quality panel]. [1] Firms aware of the Guidelines.

PMEs with an FWA; employers' written policy by size, and requests received by policy.

◂ Practice ◂ Barriers

Backup index

Backup B22

All PME estimates, % of pay

Level (vs base)	% of pay	95% CI	Status
1–2 days WFH (onsite)	≈7	5–10	Direction robust
3–4 days WFH (onsite)	≈10	7–12	Direction robust
Fully remote (onsite, long commute)	≈15	11–19	≈12 vs moderate, ≈8 vs short
Staggered hours (fixed hours)	≈0	−3 to 2	Robust: about zero
Compressed week (fixed hours)	≈7	4–10	Direction robust
Job sharing (full-time)	≈6	3–9	Hours change: not a price
Part-time (full-time)	≈4	1–7	Hours change: not a price
Low job-loss risk (high)	≈5	0–10	*not robust*: ≈2 (n.s.) with position term; ≈9 excl. same-side
Collaborative culture (hierarchical)	≈10	5–14	Context: ≈7 with position term; one task only
Short commute (long commute)	≈8	3–13	Context only

Base level in brackets. N = 1,020. Magnitudes are model-based (pay gaps shown: 17–33%). Grey = indicative.

Conditional logit, N = 1,020 PMEs, 6,120 choices; 95% CIs clustered by respondent. Pay a PME would give up for the level over the base; indicative, as gaps shown were 17–33%. Fully remote is vs a long commute; vs own commute, ≈ 13% (commute).

◂ PMEs

Fully remote valued against any commute

Fully remote vs . . .	% of pay [95% CI]	Equal-pay share, %
own commute (headline)	12.7 [9.8, 15.6]	64
excluding one panel (n = 708)	13.6 [10.5, 16.6]	68
long commute (>45 min; main model)	15.1 [11.1, 19.1]	67
moderate commute (15–45 min)	12.2 [9.0, 15.5]	64
short commute (<15 min)	7.5 [2.9, 12.1]	58
Own commute, by length		
45 min or less (n = 681)	11.0 [7.2, 14.9]	62
over 45 min (n = 305)	11.8 [6.9, 16.8]	65
Test of no difference	p = .80	p = .45

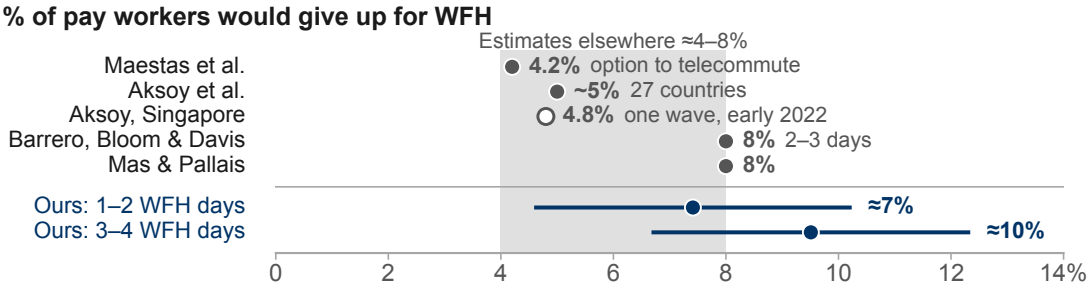
Own commute: remote effect net of the commute each PME held in the design (short .037, moderate .729, long .233). Commute is not associated with valuing hybrid work or the compressed week (1–2 WFH days: 58% vs 58%). Grey = indicative (gaps shown 17–33%). By-length values use group pay slopes, so need not bracket 12.7; equal-pay shares (62, 65) bracket 64.

◂ PMEs

Backup index

Backup B24

PME values at or above estimates abroad



Ours: indicative; lines = 95% CI. Poland, two-sided (IZA DP 2023; hybrid and remote pooled): workers give up 2.9%, employers expect a 21% wage cut.

Not like-for-like: populations, methods and definitions differ. Maestas et al. (AER 2023); Aksoy et al. (BPEA 2022); Barrero, Bloom & Davis (JEP 2023); Mas & Pallais (AER 2017); Lewandowski et al. (IZA DP 16041, 2023; ILR Review 2026: ≈ 5% hybrid, 25% fully remote).

◂ PMEs ◂ Literature

Backup index

Backup B25

PME splits: one survives correction

Split (A / B)	n	1–2 days	3–4 days	Remote	Compr.	p	p pay	q
Career penalty: y / n	455 / 565	52 / 64	52 / 69	55 / 72[a]	59 / 58	$<.001$	.002	$<.001$
excl. one panel		53 / 65	58 / 71		57 / 58	.002	.048	.013
Commute $>$ / $\leq$45 min	305 / 681	58 / 58	63 / 58	65 / 62[b]	57 / 58	.030[c]	.015[c]	.11
WFH now: y / n		58 / 58				.79		n.s.
Pay $>$ / $\leq$S$6,000	408 / 435					.91	.77	n.s.
Public / local / MNC	171/383/412					.69	.68	n.s.
Tenure: 3+ / $<$3 years	805 / 199					.44	.62	n.s.
Mothers, child 0–6 / rest	108 / 912					.28	.33	n.s.
Offered compr. week: y / n	169 / 814				59 / 58	.86[d]	.27[d]	.96

Reading: only the career-concern split survives (location only); about 40% of its gap could be choice noise, and it was asked after the choices. Excl. one panel, % of pay q = .11.

Shares: % choosing the flexible job at equal pay. p: location test (3 effects) with group-specific salary slopes, added post hoc (one slope rejects for WFH now, p = .005, at 58% vs 58%); p pay: same in % of pay; q: Benjamini–Hochberg, 7 primary splits. Blank: not tabulated (compressed week 56–61% in every group). [a]Vs moderate commute. [b]Vs own commute (p = .45; .80). [c]Hybrid alone p = .33 (.43); the pre-set one-slope test (p = .006, q = .021) comes from remote vs a long commute. [d]Old access gap not robust (access).

◂ Career concerns ◂ PME groups

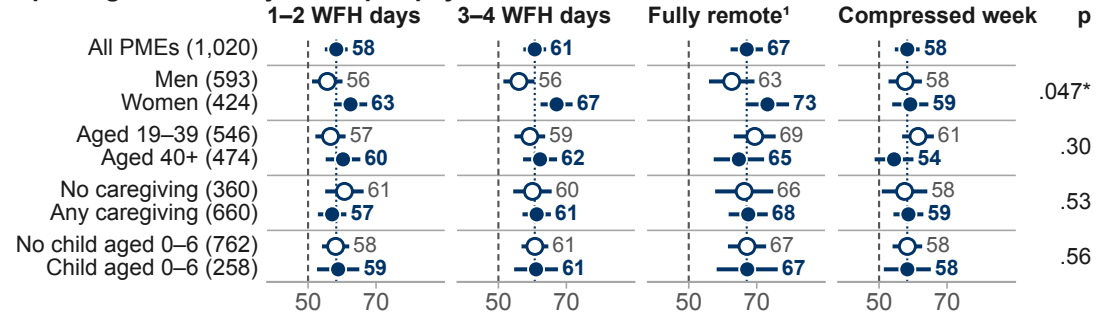
Backup index

Backup B26

No group difference established

% picking the flexible job at equal pay

dashed: 50 = no preference dotted: all PMEs



¹ vs onsite, >45 min commute. p: joint test of the three WFH effects across groups.

* Before correction for multiple tests.

Joint tests, % of pay: gender p = .43, age .09, care .66; none of 198 contrasts survives correction, so women's higher WFH shares (p = .047) are nominal. **Access:** compressed week chosen as often where offered (59% vs 58% at equal pay, p = .86); % of pay gap not robust. Detail: gender, age, care, role, edu.

◂ PME groups ◂ Career concerns

Backup index

Backup B27

Valued more where offered? Not robust

Arrangement	Offered	Not offered	Difference	Take-up, %†
WFH (any level)	valued equally either way (joint p = .84)			87 [85]
Staggered hours	≈0	≈−2	n.s. (p = .60)	69 [75]
Compressed week	≈15	≈6	+9 (p = .004), *not robust*[1]	31 [33]
Compressed, at equal pay, %[1]	59	58	n.s. (p = .86)	
Compressed, separate slopes[1]	–	–	+5.5 [−4.4, 15.4] (p = .27)	
Job sharing	≈7	≈6	n.s. (p = .82)	27 [34]
Part-time	≈15	≈2	+13 (p < .001), *not robust*[2]	26 [35]

% of pay, one pay slope for both groups. [1] *Not robust*: the compressed week was usually the cheaper option; with separate pay slopes the gap is not statistically significant, and at equal pay both groups choose it equally often. [2] Not re-estimated; part-time was also usually the lower-paid option, so also treated as not robust. Associations, not causes. N = 983 employed PMEs. Take-up = use among those with access. † Full sample [excl. one lower-quality panel]. Grey = indicative.

The gap is statistically significant only under a common pay slope. PMEs with access are less pay-sensitive (log-pay coefficient 2.79 vs 4.70); the compressed week was cheaper in 83% of PME pairs. Experience and sorting cannot be told apart.

◂ Puzzle ◂ Groups

Backup index

Backup B28

PME values stay positive

	Main	Excl. panel†	Excl. outliers	1% trim	Excl. same-side	Position term	Version CI
N	1,020	708	891	1,007	947	1,020	1,020
1–2 days WFH	≈7.4	≈7.2	≈7.4	≈7.4	≈6.5	≈7.9	5–10
3–4 days WFH	≈9.5	≈11.5	≈10.2	≈9.5	≈9.1	≈10.0	5–14
Fully remote[1]	≈15.1	≈15.1	≈14.8	≈14.9	≈14.8	≈15.8	11–19
Compressed week	≈7.4	≈5.5	≈7.6	≈7.4	≈8.2	≈6.7	4–11
Job sharing	≈6.0	≈5.6	≈6.3	≈6.3	≈5.5	≈5.9	3–9
Part-time	≈3.9	≈4.7	≈4.9	≈4.2	≈2.9	≈5.1	2–6

% of pay. Version CI: 95% CI clustered by survey version (10 clusters, approximate). Position term: left-option constant. Outliers: implausible salaries; same-side: always chose one side. [1]vs onsite with a long commute. † Drops one lower-quality PME panel. Grey = indicative.

Location, compressed and workload values stay positive (staggered ≈ 0) and statistically significant at the 5% level, except part-time without same-side respondents. Most move ≈ 1 point (e.g. trimming); without the weaker panel, 3–4 WFH days rises and compressed falls by ≈ 2. Version clustering: precision only. Job security: not robust.

◂ Robustness ◂ PMEs

Backup index

Backup B29

Yardstick: a high-turnover hire

Candidate wants ...	Wins at equal pay, % (95% CI)	Weight vs high turnover	p (same weight)	q (BH)
Compressed week	47 (41–53)	0.2×	.002	.008
Staggered hours	45 (40–50)	0.3×	.005	.011
1–2 days WFH	40 (35–45)	0.6×	.097	.17
Reduced load	38 (34–42)	0.7×	.18	.25
Part-time	31 (27–35)	1.2×	.42	.45
3–4 days WFH	31 (26–36)	1.2×	.45	.45
Fully remote	23 (18–28)	1.8×	.002	.008
Benchmark: >20% turnover risk	34 (28–39)	1×	–	–

Weight = effect on choices relative to a high turnover risk (no salary term). 50% = no preference. p = Wald test of equal weights; the ratio's delta-method interval is unreliable and not shown. q = p adjusted for 7 tests (Benjamini–Hochberg).

Employers' equal-pay share for each arrangement (50% = no preference), beside a candidate with >20% turnover risk (34%).

◂ Employers

Why employer % is secondary

	PMEs	Employers
Chose the better-paid option, %[1]	75	58
... by gap tercile (small/mid/large)	74 / 76 / 74	57 / 59 / 57
Log-likelihood: log salary	−3,417.2	−1,526.9
Log-likelihood: which paid more	−3,414.1	−1,527.2
Log salary adds to 'which paid more' (p)	$<.001$	.19
'Which paid more' adds to log salary (p)	$<.001$	.31
Fully remote vs the 17–33% gaps shown	below ($\approx$15[2])	beyond the largest (33%)

Raw shares are flat as other features vary too. Holding them fixed, PMEs respond more to larger pay gaps (p = .014), employers do not (p = .50): employer % magnitudes are weakly identified; PME magnitudes are model-based too. A lower asking salary may also signal quality. [1]PMEs: higher-paid offer; employers: cheaper candidate. [2]PMEs: vs onsite with a long commute; $\approx$13 vs their own commute. Grey = indicative.

Rankings and equal-pay shares use no pay slope.

◂ Employers

Employer reservations: two preliminary contrasts

Equal-pay share, %	Firms	1–2 days	3–4 days	Remote	Compressed[a]
Do most PME roles need on-site presence? $p < .001$, $q = .002$					
Yes, most roles	137	**27**	22	17	50
Only some or few	260	**48**	35	26	46
Worried that creativity suffers when people are apart? $p = .068$, $q = .43$					
Yes	201	39	28	**18**	42
No	196	42	34	**29**	51

- **In one model, presence holds** ($p < .001$; creativity $p = .10$). The two differ on 1–2 WFH days ($p = .004$), not for fully remote ($p = .84$).
- **Asked after the choices:** the answers may partly rationalise the hiring choices.
- **Free-slope check pending:** preliminary association under a common pay-slope model.

Model-based share of hiring choices for the flexible candidate at equal pay; 50% = no preference. p: joint test of three WFH effects, one salary slope; q: Benjamini–Hochberg, 20 splits (10% level after correction). [a]Not in the joint test; every interval includes 50%. All 20 tests.

◂ Reservations

Backup index

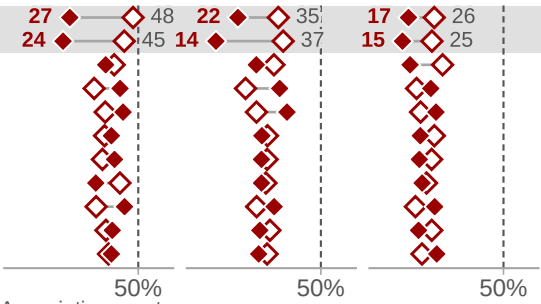
Backup B32

All employer splits

% picking the flexible candidate at equal pay

◆ with feature ◇ others

	n	1–2 WFH days	3–4 WFH days	Fully remote	p	q
Most roles need presence	137 / 260	**27** ◆ ◇ 48	**22** ◆ ◇ 35	**17** ◆ ◇ 26	<.001	**.002**
No WFH today	96 / 301	**24** ◆ ◇ 45	**14** ◆ ◇ 37	**15** ◆ ◇ 25	<.001	**.002**
Creativity suffers apart	201 / 196				.068	≥ .40
Not fully tech-ready	238 / 159				.13	≥ .40
No written policy	121 / 276				.20	≥ .40
High concern	260 / 137				.36	≥ .40
Productivity worry	223 / 174				.40	≥ .40
≤200 staff	175 / 222				.41	≥ .40
Salary offset	187 / 210				.44	≥ .40
Coordination worry	213 / 184				.48	≥ .40
1,001+ staff	82 / 315				.69	≥ .40



p: joint test of WFH effects across groups. Associations, not causes.
q: Benjamini–Hochberg, all 20 splits (11 shown). Shaded: q < .10.

Presence and no WFH today: p < .001 each, q = .002 over all 20 splits (5% level, corrected); creativity p = .07, q = .43. Preliminary: one pay slope (free-slope check pending); asked after the choices. Salary offset: agrees that offering FWAs reduces the salary needed to attract and retain PMEs (survey item).

◂ Reservations

Backup index

Backup B33

Concerns are common; creativity tracks choices

Employer view (agree = 4–5 of 5)	Agree, %	Linked to WFH choice? (p)	Reading
Worry staff are less productive at home	56	.40	No detectable link
Hybrid creates coordination problems	54	.48	No detectable link
Creativity suffers when people are apart	51	.068	Weak link: agreeing firms pick remote 18% vs 29% at equal pay
High overall concern (index $>$ 3)	65	.36[1]	No detectable link

p: joint test that agreeing firms choose WFH levels differently (creativity: n = 201 vs 196; q = .43 across all 20 employer splits tested, so not significant after correction). [1]Mean of the three items; as a continuous index, p = .089. 75% agree with at least one. Associations, not causes.

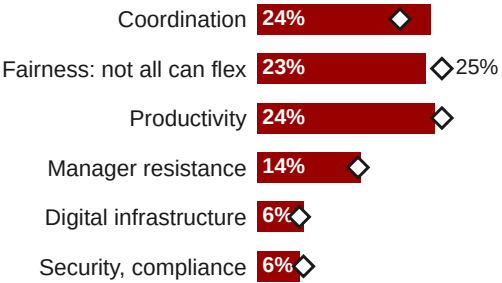
Agree = 4–5 of 5. p: joint WFH test, one pay slope. Preliminary associations: free-slope check pending; items asked after the choices. Perceived vs true cost: not separable.

Reservations

Employers: talent upside, practical hurdles

Biggest FWA challenge

% of employers ◇ ≤200 staff (n = 175)

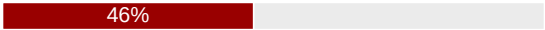


Other: 3%.

FWAs help attract, retain talent (agree)



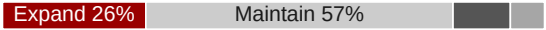
Unfair if frontline can't have FWAs (agree)



Hard to fill PME vacancies (past year)



12-month FWA plan — reduce 11% · unsure 6%



Tech-ready for remote work — not ready 7%



Surveyed employers, n = 397; few small firms (20% have ≤50 staff). We detect no size association in hiring choices; compressed-week offering rises with firm size (14, 18, 26%; p = .07). MOM (PQ, 10 Sep 2026): in 2025, nearly 7 in 10 SMEs and about 8 in 10 non-SMEs offered a scheduled FWA; definitions differ, so not comparable with the 66.4% series.

◂ Employers ◂ Reservations

Backup index

Backup B35

Why we show no industry estimates

- Industry cells hold 4 to 60 employers (11 of 17 below 25); some intervals are wider than the scale.
- Four largest industries (ICT, finance, manufacturing, professional services): we detect no difference in WFH valuations ($p = .94$).
- Reservations are associated with role needs and concerns (presence; creativity), as preliminary associations under a common pay-slope model; industry differences cannot be ruled out.

Industry mix: Industries.

◂ Reservations

Backup index

Backup B36

Raw choices, before any model

	PMEs: flexible job		Employers: flexible hire	
% choosing it (n)	**paid less**	**paid more**	**cheaper**	**dearer**
1–2 days WFH	27 (350)	88 (170)	48 (172)	34 (90)
3–4 days WFH	23 (407)	81 (167)	39 (152)	30 (73)
Fully remote	43 (320)	80 (116)	39 (110)	8 (37)
Staggered hours	22 (921)	76 (334)	61 (315)	–
Compressed week	24 (768)	87 (122)	60 (209)	37 (41)
Reduced load / job sharing	25 (641)	80 (458)	58 (239)	32 (145)
Part-time	28 (691)	80 (223)	40 (233)	24 (164)
Chose the better-paid option[1]	75 (6,120)		58 (2,382)	
Better on both other features, paid less	28 (2,563)		–	

Arrangement vs its base (onsite, fixed hours or full-time). Pay differed by 17–33%; one other feature also varied.
[1] PMEs: higher-paid offer; employers: cheaper candidate. – = not in the design.

Raw choice shares; the other attribute varies and cells are fixed by version: read as direction.

◂ Two sides ◂ Employers

Compressed week: design balance, offering, use

Design: usually the cheaper option

The lower-paid option in 83% of PME and 91% of employer pairs.

% chosen if	cheaper	dearer
PMEs: compressed	27.5	85.5
PMEs: others	24.9	75.1
Firms: compressed	67	37[c]
Firms: others	56	44

PMEs: consistent with a positive value at either price. **Firms:** mixed; "no detectable penalty" rests mainly on cheaper candidates.

Operating costs unmeasured: pilot checklist.

Surveyed firms offering it (70 of 397)

Trait	% offer	OR [95% CI]
Written policy	21.4 vs 9.1	**2.41** [1.20, 4.87]
Offers part-time[a]		**3.03** [1.67, 5.51]
Presence need		1.53 [0.88, 2.66]
Fully tech-ready		0.83 [0.48, 1.43]
Productivity concern[b]		1.61 [0.77, 3.37]
Hard to hire	18.4 vs 16.8	p = .69
Size: ≤200 / 201–1,000 / 1,001+	13.7 / 17.9 / 25.6	p = .066

Surveyed PMEs: access 21% (13% excl. one panel); take-up 31%; career concern OR 0.86 [0.44, 1.67].

Logit on size, WFH now, policy, tech, presence (N = 397); ORs are not risk ratios; policy may follow offering. [a]With other offerings (policy OR 2.16 [1.04, 4.49]). [b]With concerns, talent view, hiring, turnover: ORs 0.75–1.61, p ≥ .16. [c]41 pairs.

◂ Compressed week ◂ Zones

Backup index

Backup B38

A compressed-week pilot: checklist

Design

- Same hours, four longer days; pay and leave unchanged
- Legal, contract and collective-agreement review
- Voluntary for firms and staff; reversible without penalty
- Eligibility; fairness to staff who cannot join

Safeguards

- Service and coverage plan
- Fatigue, safety and care hours
- Workload spillovers
- Appraisal by output, not presence

Evaluation

- Outcomes: output, operating costs, coverage, retention, take-up, worker experience
- Stop and scale criteria agreed with the partners in advance
- Independent evaluation with a comparison group; worker data only with consent, never for appraisal
- Publication rule: [PI to confirm]

Why a pilot: most promising common-ground test; evidence moderate; operating costs unmeasured.

To agree: number of firms, duration, comparison group, funder, data access, report-back date.

Possible leads: SNEF with volunteer firms; NTUC co-designs safeguards; TAFEP guidance.

Both surveys: the same total hours over fewer, longer days. The hiring choices did not record rostering, coverage or fatigue.

◂ Compressed week ◂ Options

Backup index

Backup B39

Flexi-load: mostly pay for hours

Model-dependent; not a pay recommendation and not a main finding.

	Reduced load / job sharing[1]	Part-time
PMEs: value, % of pay (95% CI)	≈6 (3–9)	≈4 (1–7)
Employers: model-implied discount, %	≈24	>33
Gap, % of pay	≈18	≈32
PME choices won at equal pay, %	57	54
Employer choices won at equal pay, %	38	31
Employed PMEs using it, %[†]	6 [5]	4 [5]
Take-up with access, %[†,2]	27 [34]	26 [35]

Hours change while pay is per month, so these values are mostly pay for hours (employers' discounts ≈ pro-rata), not a flexibility premium. [1]Employers saw "reduced load", PMEs "job sharing". [2]Among employed PMEs with access. † Full sample [excl. one lower-quality panel]. Grey = indicative.

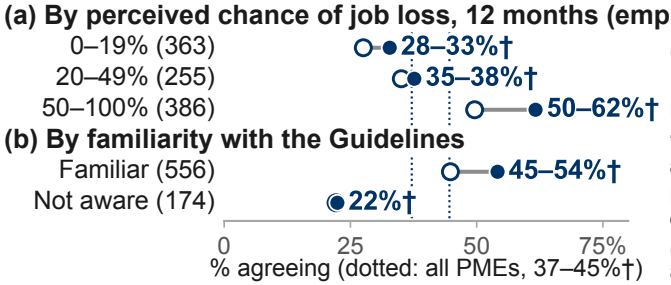
4 of 5 days = 20% fewer hours, so employer discounts near pro-rata show no sign of an extra flexibility penalty. At equal pay, part-time candidates win only 28% of choices even in firms with no presence need or creativity concern, partly reflecting pro-rata pay. MOM is reviewing the PTRG for flexi-load (COS 2026); part-time context.

◂ Options ◂ Reservations

Backup index

Backup B40

Who expects a career penalty?



(c) Formal request reported (employed, aware)

Expecting a penalty is associated with **+15 pp [9, 20]** after controls (excl. one panel: +16 pp).

Full approval: no detectable difference (p = .44).

(c) Request item partly misread; asking may shape the belief.

● all ○ excl. one panel (†) Job-loss chance: a relative index, not a probability. Associations, not causes.
(b) Gap about halves with formal requests held fixed.

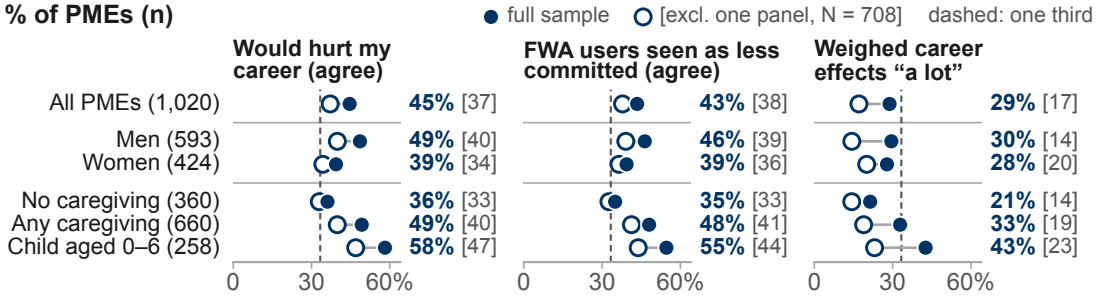
Parents of 0–6s: +12 pp after controls (+8 pp excl. one panel, p = .089). **MOM:** about 6% of resident FWA users reported a setback in 2025 (reported experience, not expectation).

Agree (4–5 of 5) that shorter or more flexible hours would hurt their career: 37–45% of surveyed PMEs (excl. one panel / all). Job loss: self-rated 12-month chance. MOM PQ 2936 (9 Sep 2026); not comparable. Chart.

◂ Barriers ◂ Career concerns

Backup index

Over a third of surveyed PMEs expect a career penalty



Career item, adjusted, excl. one panel: child 0–6 +8 pp (10% level), any caregiving +4 pp (n.s.).
Other gaps not tested. PAP–NTUC survey (Nov–Dec 2025): 36% named stigma their primary concern.

Agree = 4–5 of 5: an expected penalty, not a reported setback. Brackets exclude one lower-quality panel, which holds half the parents of children 0–6: read their bracketed value. PAP–NTUC survey: all workers, not PMEs. Who expects it.

◂ Barriers ◂ Why PMEs

Backup index

Backup B42

What we can say about the Guidelines

What we observe (2026)

- Familiar: 44–55%† of surveyed PMEs, 25–29%† of juniors, 58% of employers
- Of PMEs reporting a formal request, 4–7%† were declined (7–10%†, stricter definition): a lower bound
- More FWAs came via company policy (39–43%†) than individual request (26–30%†)
- Aware firms with a written policy got more requests (68% vs 19%; an association)

What we cannot say

- Whether the Guidelines changed outcomes (no before-and-after)
- National rates (unweighted panels)
- Why PMEs do not ask (not asked)
- How firms decide staff requests (experiment: hiring)

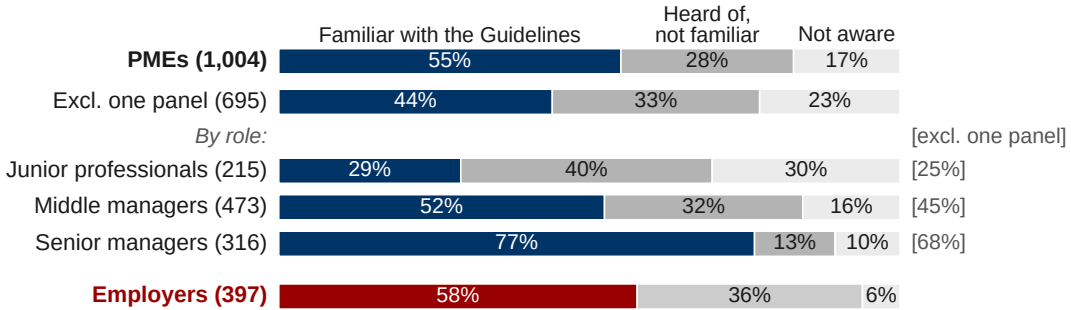
†Range across two samples: all respondents, and excluding one online panel with less reliable survey answers. See two views, table, awareness.

◂ Barriers

Backup index

Backup B43

Awareness is wide but shallow



PMEs: employed (n). [ ] = % familiar, excl. one panel. Unweighted.
PAP–NTUC survey's 58% aware: not comparable.

Brackets exclude one lower-quality panel. PAP Women's Wing–NTUC survey (online, Nov–Dec 2025; sampling not published): 58% aware; 29% know where to turn if a request is denied or mishandled.

◂ Barriers

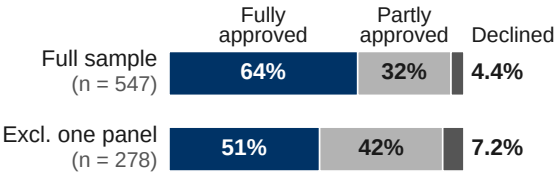
Backup index

Backup B44

Same process, two vantage points

PMEs reporting a formal request

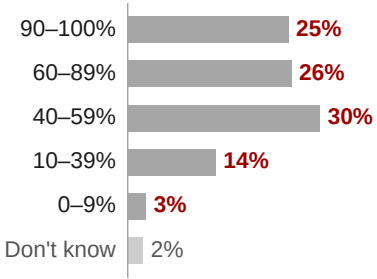
Reported outcome, %



Excl.: drops one lower-quality panel. Unweighted.

Employers: share of requests approved

(n = 203)



MOM, for comparison (definitions differ): ≈94% approved (2024 data, almost entirely before the Guidelines). After use, ≈6% of resident FWA users reported a career setback (2025): experience, not PMEs' expectation.

Different questions: PMEs report their own request; employers, their firm's approval share. Gaps may reflect partial approvals, firm vs individual rates, or managers' partial view.

Barriers

Backup index

Request outcomes in detail

PMEs' own request (n = 547 [278])	%†	Employers: share of requests approved (n = 203)	%
Fully approved	64 [51]	Nearly all (90–100%)	25
Partially approved	32 [42]	Most (60–89%)	26
Declined	4.4 [7.2]	About half (40–59%)	30
Declined, excl. automatic FWAs[1]	6.9 [10.4]	Some (10–39%)	14
		Few (0–9%)	3
		Don't know	2

Different questions: PMEs report their own request; employers, the share of all requests approved (partial approvals, firm-wide rates and managers' partial view may explain why). MOM's survey for 2024 also finds most requests approved (populations and definitions differ). Both concern existing staff, not hiring. [1]Excl. PMEs whose FWA applies automatically by company policy (base n = 317 [182]): the declined share is likely a lower bound. † Full sample [excl. one lower-quality panel].

Many PMEs with automatic FWAs reported a formal request (why); both sides cover only requests made. MOM comparators: two views.

◂ Barriers

Why no headline request rate

Base	n	Made a formal request, %
Employed and aware of the Guidelines	832	65.7
... excl. lower-quality panel	538	51.7
All employed (not aware = no request)	1,004	54.5
FWA automatic by company policy	318	72.3
By panel (aware)		
... lower-quality panel	294	91.5
... main panel	487	50.9
... no panel recorded	51	58.8

Most PMEs whose FWA came automatically by company policy also said they made a formal request, so the share is not headlined.

The item left “formal” undefined, with no “automatic” option. MOM (2024 data): 18.5% of employees who needed an FWA made a formal request.

◂ Barriers

Backup index

Backup B47

Limits in detail

Limit	What it means	Next step
Pay gaps 17–33%	% of pay is model-based; employers weakly pay-sensitive (cheaper won 58%)	A small-gap wave
60 design cells	10 versions $\times$ 6 tasks per side: intervals likely too narrow	Cluster by version
Compressed week	Cheaper in 83% (PME) and 91% (employer) of its pairs	Balance pay positions
Employer splits	One pay slope: preliminary associations, asked after the choices	Free-slope check, pending
Employer task	A hire, not a staff request; not an operating cost	Pilots that record operations
Samples	Unweighted panels, mostly large firms; one weaker PME panel (31%)	Items in MOM surveys
Request item	Misread; refusals among askers only; no why-not item	Option D items

Also: stated choices (SNEF use known); no before-and-after; 12% of salaries capped; task-1 coding. Choice results hold without the weaker panel. Next steps.

◂ Limits ◂ Robustness

Backup index

Backup B48

Sharpening the evidence

Before publication

- Employer free-slope check (presence, creativity)
- Add a position term; fix early task-1 coding
- Cluster by survey version; wild bootstrap
- Log vs rank salary models
- Code open-text comments (68% of PMEs, 58% of employers wrote one)

A follow-up wave, if supported

- Small pay gaps (0–15%) for precise prices
- Balance the compressed week across pay positions
- Ask why people do not request; reword the request item, with partial approval
- Information module (trial evidence; Guidelines; career outcomes)
- One short survey of the 490 PMEs (48%) who agreed; more needs fresh consent (follow-up)

◂ Limits ◂ Options

Backup index

Backup B49

Follow-up design, if supported

	Aim 1: do stated choices predict behaviour?	Aim 2: what changes in firms that adopt?
Outcomes	FWA take-up, job moves, promotion, appraisal vs each PME's choices; checked without one panel	Productivity, retention, hires, exits in volunteer pilot firms (Option A or C), vs a comparison group
Consent now	490 of 1,020 PMEs (48%) agreed to one short (about 5-minute) survey in 6–12 months (Feb–Aug 2027)	None: the employer survey asked no re-contact question
Partner roles	**NTUC:** reach members beyond online panels; **MOM:** linkage only with fresh consent, under its data rules	**SNEF:** recruit fresh volunteer member firms; **MOM:** firm linkage only with consent
Templates	Maestas et al.: 56% matched up to 3 years later (validity)	Trip.com hybrid trial: quits fell 7.20% to 4.80%; German LPP: consented employer–employee linkage, six waves 2012–2024

Consent scope: 490 PMEs consented to one short survey in 6–12 months; further waves, linkage and firm-side work require fresh consent.

Data owner, funder and publication: [PI to confirm] (governance).

Consenters lean to one online panel (40%) and to caregivers (52.6% vs 39.7% agreed); without that panel, 296 of 708 (42%) agreed.

◂ Conclusion

Backup index

Option A: put compressed weeks on the menu and test them

Zone: A, common ground **Strength:** moderate; operating costs unmeasured

The evidence

PMEs value it (≈ 7% of pay; 58% at equal pay); employers show no detectable hiring penalty (47%; wide interval). 1 surveyed firm in 6 offers it, more often with a written policy (21% vs 9%). It was the cheaper option in 83% (PME) and 91% (employer) of its pairs.

Owner and first step

SNEF, with volunteer member firms: put it on the written menu and test it in a bounded, evaluated pilot (checklist). **NTUC:** co-design safeguards. **TAFEP:** guidance.

Builds on

TAFEP and IHRP resources; SNEF guidance on FWA requests.

What it is not

Not shorter hours (same hours, four longer days), a mandate or a case for lower pay; not shown to be costless.

What to watch

Output, coverage, rostering, fatigue; take-up where available (31–33%†).

Associations, not causes: a policy may follow offering. Hiring choices do not measure operating costs. †Range across two samples: all respondents, and excluding one online panel with less reliable survey answers.

◂ Options ◂ Puzzle

Backup index

Option B: fit arrangements to the role, with flexi-load

Zone: B, depends on the role **Strength:** moderate; preliminary associations

The evidence

Where most roles need presence, 1–2 WFH days win 27% of hiring choices at equal pay (48% elsewhere), a compressed week 50% ($p < .001$ vs 1–2 days). Presence: $p < .001$ ($q = .002$ over 20 splits; preliminary). Part-time: 28% even with neither presence need nor creativity concern.

Owner and first step

Firms, with SNEF: review which tasks need presence; a compressed week may fit where WFH does not; use flexi-load where fewer hours, not location, address the need. Job Redesign+: up to 70% of qualifying costs for SMEs, 50% for others. **MOM:** PTRG review.

Builds on

EWTP (Mar 2026), linked by MOM to FWAs.

What it is not

Not one-size-fits-all; not a quota.

What to watch

Fairness to staff without FWAs (top challenge, $\leq$200 staff); part-time access (COS 2026: under half who needed it got it).

Associations; asked after the choices; free-slope check pending. Flexi-load.

◂ Options ◂ Reservations

Backup index

Backup B52

Option C: a 3–4-day WFH pilot where roles allow

Zone: C, far apart **Strength:** exploratory

The evidence

3–4 WFH days and fully remote win 31% and 23% of hiring choices at equal pay. Fully remote wins 18% where firms worry that creativity suffers apart, against 29% elsewhere (a weak association, p = .07; preliminary, one pay slope). In the 36% of firms with neither that concern nor a presence need, 3–4 WFH days no longer differ detectably from 50% (44%), but fully remote still does (38%). Abroad, a six-month hybrid trial cut quits by a third.

Owner and first step

Volunteer firms, with SNEF and NTUC: a 3–4-day WFH pilot in roles without presence needs; outcomes agreed upfront; independent evaluation; stop criteria set in advance.
Convenor, funding and publication rule: for the partners.

Builds on

Trials abroad (managers' productivity view: −2.6% to +1.0%).

What it is not

Not a push for fully remote work (mixed evidence; some studies find lower productivity); not a mandate; no pay change.

What to watch

Output, retention, collaboration; whether managers' concerns are borne out.

Bloom, Han & Liang (2024); Barrero, Bloom & Davis (2023); Emanuel & Harrington (2024).

◂ Options ◂ Two sides

Backup index

Backup B53

Option D: why-not-request and partial-approval items

Zone: all (measurement) **Strength:** gap documented

The evidence

Firms need not report requests to MOM; in MOM's survey, 18.5% of those needing an FWA made a formal request (data for 2024). MOM publishes request rates, not reasons; our survey had no why-not item, and our request item was partly misread. Of PMEs reporting a request, 4–7%† were declined (a lower bound), 32–42%† partly approved. 37–45%† expect a career penalty; it goes with more requests, not fewer.

Owner and first step

MOM (MRSD), with NTUC and SNEF: check its survey, then add the items not yet asked: why those who need an FWA do not ask, and whether a request was approved in full, with changes, or declined (draft).

Builds on

MOM's employee survey; partners' outreach channels.

What it is not

Not a new reporting duty for firms; not an evaluation of the Guidelines.

What to watch

Partial approvals; junior PMEs' awareness (25–29%† familiar); expected penalty vs MOM's reported setbacks (≈ 6% of FWA users, 2025).

†Range across two samples: all respondents, and excluding one online panel with less reliable survey answers.

◂ Options ◂ Barriers

Backup index

Backup B54

Option D: draft survey items

First step (employees)

1. **Why not ask:** if you needed an FWA but did not request one, why not? (career concern; did not know how; expected refusal; automatic)
2. **Outcome:** approved as requested / with changes / declined.

Also (employees)

3. Formal request: add “applies automatically”.
4. Guidelines awareness; would flexible work affect your career?

Later, if partners agree (establishments)

5. Any formal FWA request in the past 12 months?
6. Share approved as requested, with changes, or declined?
7. Roles needing on-site presence: which arrangements are offered?

Draft for MRSD, to check against EWC and CoE questionnaires; item 1 appears new. Employee items first; any establishment items would sit in existing MOM surveys, for the partners to decide. Option D.

◂ Options ◂ Conclusion

Backup index

Technical: all 20 employer split tests

Split	p	q
Presence need	$<.001$	.002
No WFH now	$<.001$	.002
Creativity concern	.068	
Designation	.086	
Knows Guidelines	.11	
Tech readiness	.13	
Written policy	.20	

Split	p	q
Talent benefit	.30	
Concern index	.36	
Productivity concern	.40	
Size $\leq$200	.41	
Salary offset	.44	
Hard to hire	.44	
Coordination concern	.48	

Split	p	q
Hiring role	.50	
PME turnover	.56	
PME share $\geq$50%	.59	
Size 1,001+	.69	
12-month plan	.77	
Fairness concern	.98	

%, 95% CI	1–2 days	3–4 days	Remote	Compr.
Neither (36%): equal pay	54 [45, 62]	44 [35, 53]	38 [27, 48]	57 [48, 67]
Gap share: presence	46 [20, 73]	17 [5, 30]	9 [0, 19]	unstable
Gap share: creativity	4 [$-$25, 33]	10 [$-$8, 27]	16 [2, 30]	unstable

Technical appendix, not for projection. p: location test, one salary slope (free-slope check pending); q: Benjamini–Hochberg over 20 splits, $\geq$ .40 where blank. Neither: no presence need or creativity concern; fully remote differs from 50% (p = .02), the other levels do not (p $\geq$ .11); part-time 28% [21, 35]. Gap shares: a cross-side decomposition, not a market gap; imprecise associations that reweight observed firm groups (presence, 1–2-day shortfall below 50%: 89% [23, 155]). Items asked after the choices. Summary.

◂ Reservations

Public wording

We say

- PMEs strongly prefer hybrid work: about 7–10% of pay, indicative, never a pay cut.
- At equal pay, hybrid or compressed-week jobs win about six in ten choices (vs 50%).
- Hiring: no detectable penalty for a compressed week; fully remote last (a ranking).
- Reservations: 1–2 WFH days where most roles need presence; remote with the creativity concern; preliminary (one pay slope).
- Compressed week: most promising common-ground test; evidence moderate; operating costs unmeasured.
- Over a third of surveyed PMEs expect a career penalty; refusals are a lower bound.

We avoid

Employer % of salary as a price, or WTP as a pay cut; a request rate; equal-pay shares as shares of people, or compared across sides; “easy”, “low cost”, “no cost”, “indifferent”; associations or nulls as causes or proof; Guidelines effects on provision, requests or approvals.

◂ Two sides ◂ Conclusion

Backup index

Employer % of salary

Model-dependent; not a pay recommendation and not a main finding.

Candidate (vs base)	Discount, %	95% CI	Status
1–2 days WFH (onsite)	≈20	10–30	Direction robust
3–4 days WFH (onsite)	>33	26–>33	
Fully remote (onsite)	beyond the largest discount tested (33%)		
Staggered hours (fixed hours)	≈10	0–20	*not robust* (version clusters)
Compressed week (fixed hours)	≈7	−5 to 19	No detectable reservation; mostly the cheaper candidate
4-day reduced load (full-time)	≈24	15–32	≈ pro-rata for fewer hours
Part-time (full-time)	>33	27–>33	≈ pro-rata for fewer hours
High turnover risk >20% (<10%)	≈31	21–>33	Benchmark
Moderate turnover risk 10–20% (<10%)	≈5	−5 to 15	Robust: no detectable reservation

Lower candidate salary at which the model predicts a 50:50 hiring choice. Weakly identified: a cheaper-candidate indicator fits as well as log salary (why). Pay gaps shown: 17–33%; values beyond print as >33. Grey = indicative.

Firmer result: the ranking at equal pay (yardstick).

◂ Employers

Backup index

Backup B58

Gap, % of pay: indicative

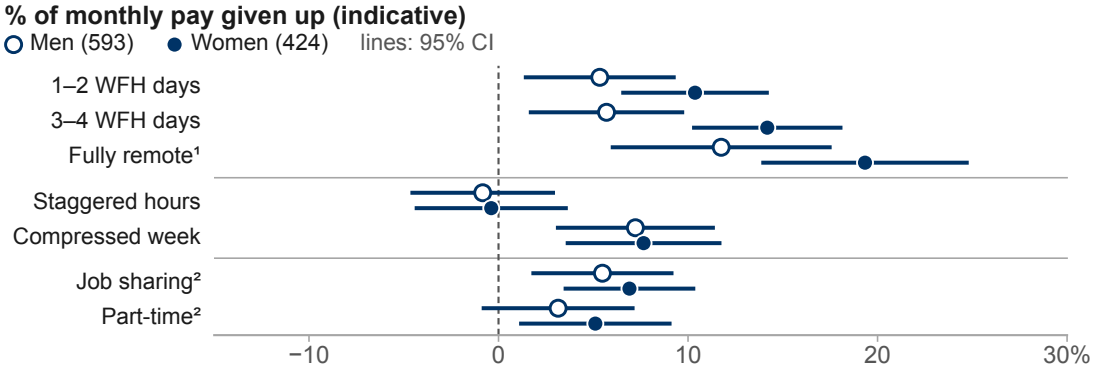
Model-dependent; not a pay recommendation and not a main finding.

Arrangement	PMEs' value	Employers' model-implied discount	Gap (95% CI)	Zone
Compressed week	≈7	≈7	0 (−13 to 12), n.s.	A: common ground
1–2 days WFH	≈7	≈20	12 (2–23), p = .020	B: depends on the role
Staggered hours	≈0	≈10, *not robust*	–	Little at stake
3–4 days WFH	≈10	>33	26 (16–37)	C: far apart
Fully remote	≈15[1]	beyond the largest discount tested (33%)	widest; *not robust*	C: far apart
Reduced load / job sharing	≈6	≈24	≈18	Pay for hours
Part-time	≈4	>33	≈32	Pay for hours

Zones are descriptive; these numbers are indicative. Gap = discount minus value. Pay gaps shown were 17–33%, so zones rest on equal-pay choices; employer discounts beyond 33 print as >33. n.s. = not statistically significant at the 5% level. [1]vs onsite with a long commute. Grey = indicative.

◂ Two sides

Estimates by gender



¹ vs onsite, >45 min commute. ² Fewer hours, same monthly pay. Base: onsite, fixed hours, full-time.

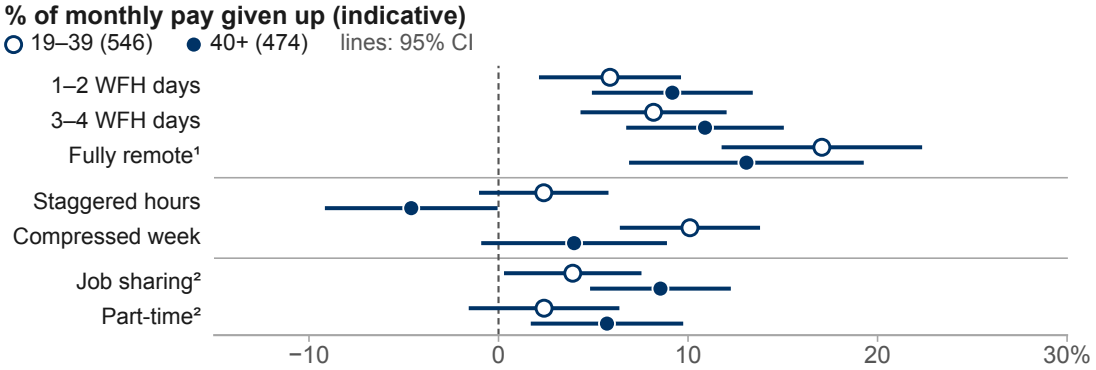
No statistically significant gender difference (joint test p = .43). All groups.

PME groups

Backup index

Backup B60

Estimates by age



¹ vs onsite, >45 min commute. ² Fewer hours, same monthly pay. Base: onsite, fixed hours, full-time.

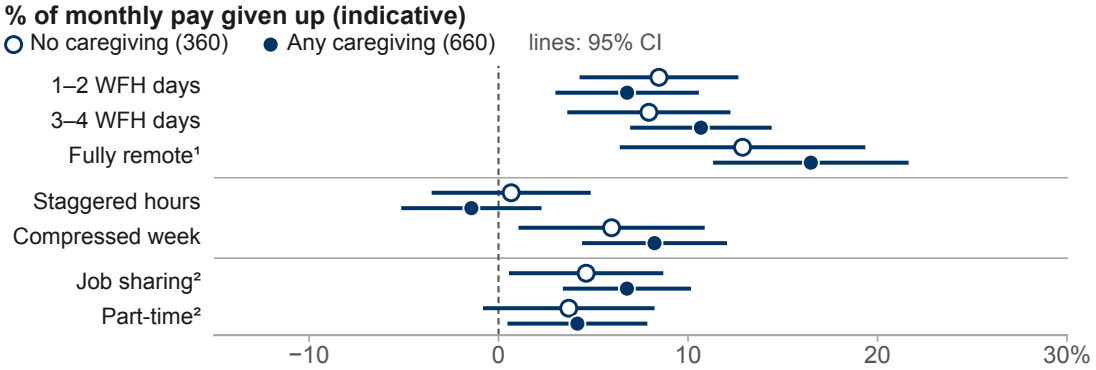
Ages 19–39 vs 40+; not statistically significant (joint test p = .09). All groups.

PME groups

Backup index

Backup B61

Estimates by caregiving

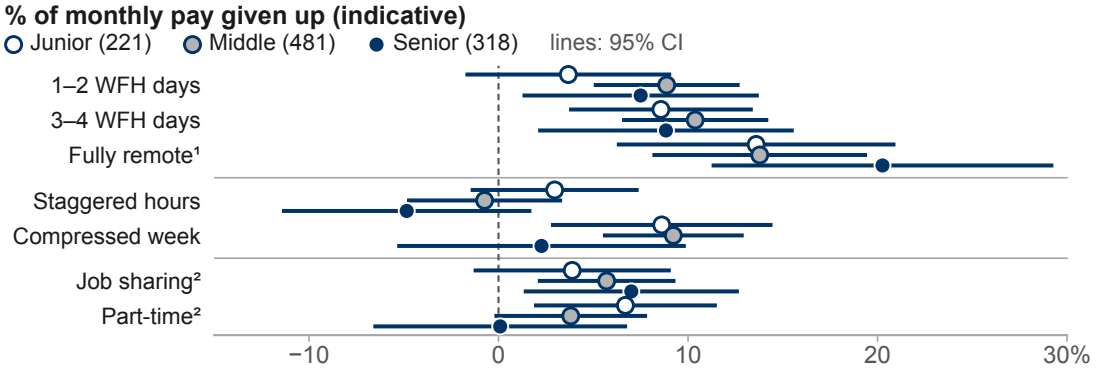


¹ vs onsite, >45 min commute. ² Fewer hours, same monthly pay. Base: onsite, fixed hours, full-time.

No caregiving vs any; not statistically significant (p = .66). All groups.

PME groups

Estimates by role level



¹ vs onsite, >45 min commute. ² Fewer hours, same monthly pay. Base: onsite, fixed hours, full-time.

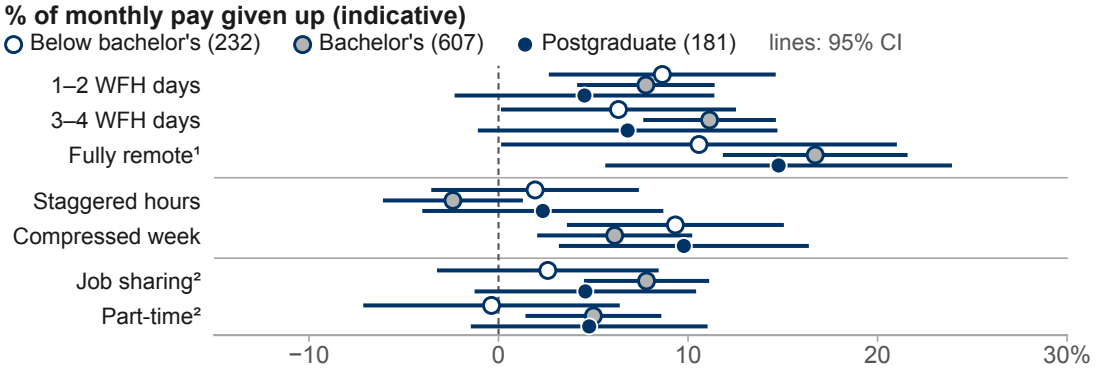
Junior, middle and senior; not statistically significant (p = .15). All groups.

PME groups

Backup index

Backup B63

Estimates by education



¹ vs onsite, >45 min commute. ² Fewer hours, same monthly pay. Base: onsite, fixed hours, full-time.

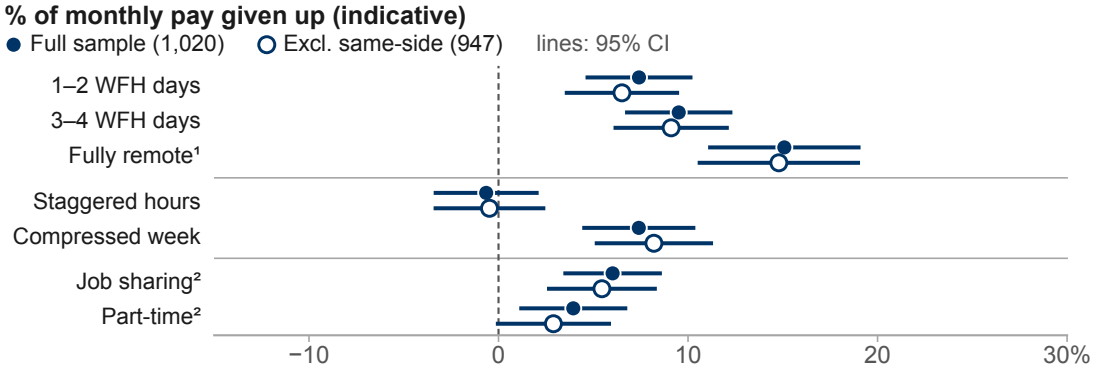
Three education levels; not statistically significant (p = .56). All groups.

PME groups

Backup index

Backup B64

Without same-side respondents

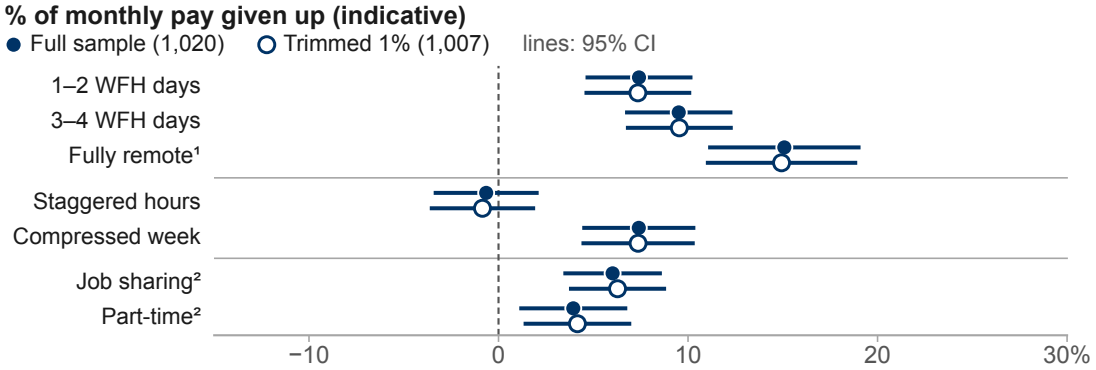


¹ vs onsite, >45 min commute. ² Fewer hours, same monthly pay. Base: onsite, fixed hours, full-time.

Drops 73 PMEs who always picked one side; location and compressed-week values move ≤1 point. PME checks.

Robustness

Trimming extreme salaries



¹ vs onsite, >45 min commute. ² Fewer hours, same monthly pay. Base: onsite, fixed hours, full-time.

Drops the top and bottom 1% of salaries. PME checks.

Robustness

Backup index

Backup B66